

GNOME. In 1999, Sun Microsystems released StarOffice, an open source office suite that developed into the modern OpenOffice. The year 2007 saw the Java development kit (JDK) released as open source by Sun Microsystems. In July 2009, Google announced the development of Google Chrome OS, a web-based open source operating system. Many other exciting developments await the open source community.



Early this year, Google announced its intention to develop the open source Google Chrome OS

1.2 Open source licenses

Now that we are familiar with what open source is and also with its history, how do we ensure software remains open source?

The legal instrument that regulates the use and redistribution of a computer programme is known as a software licence. Proprietary software while allowing the user to use the program, maintains that the software remains the property of the vendor and limits the uses it can be put to. Microsoft Windows, for example, forbids among other things attempts to reverse engineer it, use a copy on multiple systems and publish data related to tests among other things.

While some licenses, such as the GNU GPL makes it mandatory for the user to ensure that any derivative of the software he develops remains open source, others such as the MIT license allows the user to make the code a part of a proprietary software of his own.

Open source software come with open source licences. These licences, while regulating programme usage, also permit freedom including access to the source code and the right to modify and redistribute

Licenses under GNU GPL, are known as 'copyleft' licenses. Other methods used by software licenses to ensure that the software remains truly open source include practices such as patent retaliation (a clause denying the user the open source freedoms if he attempts to patent any part of the software/derivative developed by him). Tivoization is aimed at